Standard Operating Procedure (SOP): Publishing a Website Content Update

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Status: Portfolio demonstration sample

Process owner: Website Content Team

Last reviewed: 29 October 2026

1. Purpose

This SOP defines a repeatable process for preparing, reviewing, publishing, and verifying a routine website content update. It is designed to reduce avoidable publishing errors and make responsibilities clear.

2. Scope

Use this procedure for updates to existing website pages or blog posts in a content management system (CMS), including text changes, links, metadata, and approved images.

This SOP does not cover website redesigns, production code deployments, emergency security changes, or changes that require formal legal or regulatory approval. Follow the relevant specialist process for those activities.

3. Roles and responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Content owner	Supplies the approved copy and confirms factual accuracy
Editor / SEO reviewer	Checks clarity, style, links, metadata, and search requirements
Publisher	Enters approved content into the CMS and publishes it
Final checker	Verifies the live page and records the result

One person may perform more than one role on a small team. The publisher should not approve their own unreviewed factual claims when an independent reviewer is available.

4. Required inputs

Before starting, confirm that you have:

- Final copy approved by the content owner
- Target page URL or draft location
- Approved images and their alternative text, where applicable
- Required page title and meta description

- Destination URLs for internal and external links
- Any scheduled publication date or time

If a required input is missing or contradictory, pause and ask the content owner for clarification.

5. Procedure

Step 1 — Create or open the draft

1. Sign in to the approved CMS using your own account.
2. Open the target page or create a new draft when authorised.
3. Confirm that you are editing the correct page, language, and site environment.
4. Save the draft before making substantial changes.

Checkpoint: The page title and URL identify the intended page.

Step 2 — Enter the approved content

1. Add the approved heading structure and body copy.
2. Apply lists, tables, links, and emphasis consistently.
3. Add only approved images or downloadable files.
4. Enter alternative text that communicates the purpose of meaningful images. Use empty alternative text for purely decorative images when the CMS supports it.
5. Add the approved page title and meta description in the relevant SEO fields.
6. Preview the draft on desktop and mobile layouts.

Do not invent claims, prices, dates, testimonials, or product capabilities to fill gaps in the supplied copy.

Step 3 — Run the pre-publication review

Check each item before publishing:

- [ ] The content matches the approved source.
- [ ] Spelling, grammar, and terminology are consistent.
- [ ] Headings follow a logical hierarchy.
- [ ] Internal and external links point to the intended destinations.
- [ ] Images display correctly and have suitable alternative text.
- [ ] Page title and meta description are present and within the team's guidance.
- [ ] No draft notes, placeholder text, or confidential information remain.
- [ ] The layout is usable on desktop and mobile.
- [ ] The content owner or required reviewer has approved the final draft.

Record any failed check and resolve it before proceeding.

Step 4 — Publish

1. Confirm the correct publication status and schedule.

2. Recheck the page title and target URL.
3. Publish only after all required approvals are recorded.
4. Copy the live URL into the task record.
5. Note the publisher, publication date, and time.

If the CMS shows an unexpected warning or the wrong page is selected, stop rather than publishing by guesswork.

Step 5 — Verify the live page

Open the live URL in a private/incognito browser window or a session that is not relying on the CMS preview.

Verify that:

- The page loads successfully.
- The published text and headings are correct.
- Links open the expected destinations.
- Images and downloadable files work.
- The page is readable on mobile.
- The page title and metadata appear as expected where tools are available.
- No accidental draft content or formatting problems are visible.

If a serious issue is found, follow the site's correction or rollback process. Do not assume that editing the draft automatically fixes the live page.

Step 6 — Close the task

Record:

- Live URL
- Publication date and time
- Reviewer and publisher
- Checks completed
- Any known issues and follow-up owner

Mark the task complete only after live verification.

6. Exception handling

Issue	Required action
Copy is not approved	Keep the page in draft and request approval
Link is broken or incorrect	Correct it and repeat the link check
Wrong page was published	Notify the site owner immediately and follow the rollback/correction process
Live page differs from preview	Check publication status, caching, and CMS guidance; escalate if unresolved

Issue	Required action
CMS is unavailable	Do not attempt an unapproved workaround; notify the site owner and reschedule

7. Access and security

- Use individual authorised accounts.
- Do not share passwords or authentication codes.
- Do not paste secrets, personal data, or confidential customer information into public content.
- Use only approved tools and storage locations for source files.

8. Completion criteria

The task is complete when the approved content is live at the intended URL, all required checks pass, and the task record contains the live link and verification result.

9. Revision history

Version	Date	Change
1.0	29 October 2026	Initial portfolio demonstration version

Portfolio note: This is a general demonstration SOP. Adapt approval roles, CMS-specific steps, and rollback instructions to the organisation's actual policies before operational use.